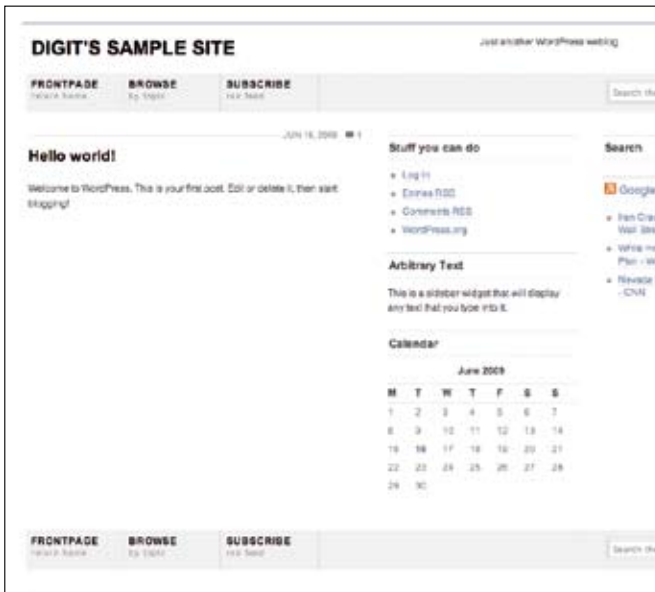


Keep an eye on india.wordcamp.org to find out when the next WordCamp—an event designed around WordPress—will be held

WordPress applications for the iPhone (and soon, for the BlackBerry) let you update your site from wherever you are



Gridfocus is a simple theme that gives you three sidebars to pollute with widgets

on the Activate link against it.

If the pre-made themes don't meet your needs, you can exploit the almighty WordPress Loop to create one of your own.

Getting Started With A Theme

There aren't enough pages for us to get into the nitty-gritties of theme design, but you need two files to get started: a style.css, that will contain all the CSS styles for your theme, and index.php, which will be the template that all your pages are based on. At the heart of it all

the_post(); ?>

<!--this is where you display content-->
<?php endwhile;?>

This code gets your posts from the database, ten at a time, ready for you to display as you want it. For example, let's say you have a three-column layout, and the HTML looks something like this:

```
<div id="column-1"></div>
<div id="column-2"></div>
<div id="column-3"></div>
```



The Advertising Manager plugin lets you put an ad widget in your sidebar

is this bit of code, called the WordPress Loop:

```
<?php if ( have_posts() ) : while ( have_posts() ) :
```

Let's say that you want posts from the News category in column 1, the titles of all your posts in column 2, and a sidebar that you can stick

widgets into in column 3.

First, the news. Here, we'll use the query_posts() function, which lets you change the way that WordPress fetches posts from the database.

```
<!--start a loop in column-1 for news-->
<div id="column-1">
<?php
```

```
query_posts('category_name=News'); //
restrict only to the
News category
//start
```

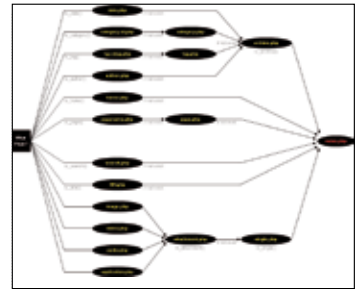
```
the loop
if (
have_posts() ) : while
( have_posts() ) :
the_post();
?>
<h1><?php the_title();?></h1>
<div
class="excerpt"><?php
the_excerpt();?></div>
<a
href="<?php the_permalink();?>">Read
More..</a>
<?php
endwhile;?>
</div>
```

As you can see, WordPress gives you functions that are quite self-explanatory: use the_title() to display the title, the_excerpt() to display the post's excerpt (or the_content() to show all the content), and so on.

Column 2 is much the same:

```
<!--start a loop
in column-2 for post
titles-->
<div id="column-2">
<?php
//start
the loop
if (
have_posts() ) : while
( have_posts() ) :
the_post();
?>
<h3><a
href="<?php the_permalink();?>"><?php
the_title();?></h3></a>
```

```
<?php
endwhile;?>
</div>
As far as index.php is
concerned, column 3 is simple:
<div id="column-2">
```



Template hierarchy shows which files it's expecting in your theme (From: WordPress Codex)

```
<?php get_sidebar();?>
</div>
But this means your theme
now needs two more files:
sidebar.php and functions.php.
Create a new file called sidebar.
php and enter this:
<ul id="sidebar">
<?php if (!function_exists('dynamic_sidebar') || !dynamic_sidebar()) : ?>
<li>
This sentence will appear if
you haven't chosen any widgets.
</li>
<?php endif; ?>
</ul>
```

This makes your sidebar dynamic, and hence capable of holding widgets. The second part of this activity is registering the sidebar. Create a new file called functions.php, and enter this bit of code:

```
<?php
if ( function_exists('register_sidebar') )
register_sidebar();
?>
```

That covers the most essential (and probably the most useful) aspects of writing a theme. Obviously, the job doesn't end here. You should create templates for categories, single posts, pages, and any type of content that you want to make specific designs for.

Developing your own theme gives you much tighter control over the way your posts – and ads – are displayed, and even if you're just modifying a theme you downloaded, it's worth your time to see what the Loop is capable of. For more, visit the exceptionally well-documented WordPress Codex at codex.wordpress.org.